ZAKHEERA AI SOLUTIONS (PRIVATE) LIMITED

Employee Handbook 2024

Company rules, conduct and employee expectations

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Policy owner	Human Resources
Applies to	All employees
Approved by	Chief Executive Officer and Head of Human Resources
HR contact	hr@zakheera.ai | Extension 2200 | HR Helpdesk on the ZakheeraHR portal

1. Welcome and Company Overview

ZAKHEERA AI Solutions (Private) Limited, referred to as ZAKHEERA or the Company, was founded in 2019 and builds applied artificial intelligence products for banks, asset managers, insurers and retail businesses in Pakistan and the Gulf region. The Company has about 220 employees. The head office is in Karachi (Shahrah-e-Faisal). Regional offices are in Lahore (Gulberg) and Islamabad (Blue Area).

This Handbook summarises the rules, rights and expectations that apply to every employee. Where a topic has its own detailed policy (leave, travel, remote work and so on), the detailed policy prevails over this summary. Where the Handbook and Pakistani law differ, the law prevails.

2. Company Values

- **Amanat (Trust):** We protect client data and company information as a trust placed in us.
- **Itqan (Craft):** We build carefully, test thoroughly and document our work.
- **Taawun (Collaboration):** We share knowledge and help teammates succeed.
- **Nafa (Impact):** We build products that create real value for Pakistani users and businesses.
- **Dayanat (Integrity):** We act honestly, disclose conflicts and speak up about wrongdoing.

3. Employment Categories

Category	Description	Key terms
Permanent	Regular full-time employee after successful probation	Full benefits, 30 or 60 days notice
Probationary	New hire during the first 3 months (extendable up to 6 months in total)	Leave accrues, medical cover from day 1, 14 days notice
Contract	Fixed-term engagement, 6 to 24 months	Benefits as per contract, no gratuity unless stated
Intern / Trainee	Grade G1, 3 to 6 months, stipend based	Stipend, no provident fund, 7 days notice
Consultant	Independent professional engaged by service agreement	Not an employee, no benefits

4. Grade Structure

Grade	Typical title	Grade	Typical title
G1	Intern / Trainee	G5	Team Lead / Manager
G2	Associate Engineer / Analyst	G6	Senior Manager / Director
G3	Engineer / Analyst	G7	VP and C-level
G4	Senior Engineer / Senior Analyst		

5. Working Hours and Attendance

- Standard office hours are Monday to Friday, 9:00 AM to 6:00 PM, including a one hour break (8 working hours per day, 40 per week). Saturday and Sunday are weekly off days.
- Core collaboration hours are 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM. All employees must be available online or in office during core hours, including hybrid and remote days.
- A grace period of 15 minutes (until 9:15 AM) applies. Up to 3 late arrivals per calendar month within the grace period are not recorded. From the 4th late arrival, half a day of casual leave is deducted.
- Attendance is recorded through the biometric terminal or the ZakheeraHR mobile app check-in. Employees on remote days check in on the app.
- Missing check-ins must be regularised in ZakheeraHR within 3 working days. Unregularised absences are treated as unpaid leave.
- During Ramadan, office hours are 9:00 AM to 4:00 PM with a 30 minute break, unless announced otherwise by HR.

6. Dress Code

The dress code is business casual. Casual dress (clean jeans and polo or kurta) is allowed on Fridays and on days without client meetings. Formal attire is required for client-facing meetings and presentations. Clothing with offensive slogans is not permitted.

7. Code of Conduct

Every employee must treat colleagues, clients and vendors with respect, follow Company policies and obey applicable law. The following behaviour is prohibited and may lead to disciplinary action up to termination:

- Harassment, bullying, discrimination or retaliation of any kind (see the Grievance and Escalation Procedure).
- Fraud, falsification of records, forged medical certificates or expense claims.
- Theft, misuse or damage of Company property or data.
- Working under the influence of alcohol or illegal substances, or possessing them on premises.
- Sharing confidential or client information without authorisation.
- Absence without approval for 3 or more consecutive working days.
- Violence, threats or weapons on Company premises.

8. Conflict of Interest, Gifts and Anti-Bribery

- Employees must disclose any outside business, directorship or financial interest in a client, vendor or competitor to HR in writing.

- Outside employment, including freelancing, requires prior written approval from the Head of HR if it relates to AI, data or software.
- Gifts from clients or vendors above PKR 5,000 in value must be declared to HR and may be refused or donated to charity. Cash gifts are never acceptable.
- Bribes, kickbacks and facilitation payments are strictly prohibited.

9. Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

All code, models, datasets, prompts, designs and documentation created by an employee during employment or using Company resources are the property of ZAKHEERA. Employees sign a Confidentiality and IP Assignment Agreement on joining. Confidentiality obligations continue for 3 years after leaving, and indefinitely for client personal data and trade secrets.

10. IT Acceptable Use and Generative AI Guidelines

- Company laptops, email and systems are for business use. Limited personal use is allowed if it does not affect work or security.
- Use of the Company VPN and multi-factor authentication is mandatory. Passwords must not be shared.
- Client data, source code and personal data must never be pasted into public generative AI tools. Only approved tools (the Company-hosted LLM gateway and enterprise licensed assistants) may be used for work content.
- AI-generated code and content must be reviewed by the employee, who remains responsible for the output.
- Lost or stolen devices must be reported to IT Security (security@zakheera.ai) within 2 hours of discovery.
- The Company may monitor Company systems for security and compliance in line with law.

11. Social Media

Employees may not speak on behalf of the Company on social media unless authorised by Marketing. Posting client names, project details, internal screenshots or negative statements about colleagues or clients is prohibited.

12. Equal Opportunity and Anti-Harassment

ZAKHEERA provides equal opportunity regardless of gender, religion, ethnicity, disability or marital status. The Company complies with the Protection Against Harassment of Women at the Workplace Act 2010 and has a standing Inquiry Committee. Complaints are handled under the Grievance and Escalation Procedure. Retaliation against a complainant is a serious offence.

13. Health, Safety and Prayer Facilities

Each office has first aid kits, fire exits, extinguishers and trained fire wardens. Fire drills occur twice a year. Prayer rooms and a quiet room are available in all offices. Employees must report accidents to HR within 24 hours. Backup power (UPS and generator) supports essential systems during load shedding.

14. Disciplinary Procedure

Step	Action	Notes
1	Verbal warning	Recorded by manager and HR for minor issues
2	Written warning	Placed in personnel file, valid for 12 months

Step	Action	Notes
3	Final written warning	Valid for 12 months, may include suspension
4	Show cause notice and inquiry	Employee gets 7 calendar days to reply, may be heard by an inquiry panel
5	Termination	For gross misconduct or repeated violations, with notice or payment in lieu as per law

Gross misconduct (fraud, theft, harassment, serious data breach, violence) may skip steps 1 to 3. Suspension with pay may be applied during an inquiry, normally for no more than 30 days.

15. Policy Index

Topic	Document
Salary, tax, PF, bonuses	Compensation and Payroll Guide
Medical and life insurance	Health and Insurance Benefits
All types of leave and holidays	Leave Policy
Joining formalities	Onboarding and Joining Guide
Reviews, ratings, increments	Performance Review and Appraisal Policy
Hybrid work and WFH	Remote and Hybrid Work Policy
Business travel claims	Travel and Expense Reimbursement
Complaints and harassment	Grievance and Escalation Procedure
Resignation and final settlement	Exit and Resignation Procedure

16. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: What are the official working hours?
A: 9:00 AM to 6:00 PM, Monday to Friday, with a one hour break. Core hours are 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM.

Q: How many late arrivals are allowed?
A: Three per month within the 15 minute grace period (until 9:15 AM). From the fourth, half a day of casual leave is deducted.

Q: Can I use ChatGPT or other public AI tools with client data?
A: No. Client data, source code and personal data must not be entered into public AI tools. Use only the approved Company LLM gateway.

Q: Can I freelance on the side?
A: Only with prior written approval from the Head of HR if the work relates to AI, data or software.

Q: What is the dress code on Fridays?
A: Casual dress is allowed on Fridays and non-client days. Formal attire is needed for client meetings.

Q: What happens after a written warning?
A: It stays on file for 12 months. A further violation can lead to a final written warning or a show cause notice.

Q: What is the limit for accepting gifts?
A: Gifts worth more than PKR 5,000 must be declared to HR. Cash gifts are never allowed.